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History and Trends in U.S. Bound Migration from a Mexican Town

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This article examines historical trends in U.S. bound migration from a rural Mexican town. The data consist of detailed migration histories collected for all town residents in 1978. From these histories, successive migrant cohorts were constructed for the period 1940–1978. Analysis of these cohorts indicates that prior to 1965, migration was limited primarily to males working in the United States as *braceros*. Since 1965, migration has been characterized by the increased participation of women and children, and by the growing predominance of legal U.S. residents among migrants. Trends in the size and composition of migrant cohorts over the thirty-eight year period are related to shifting U.S. immigration policies.

This article examines historical trends in U.S. bound migration from a rural Mexican sending community by analyzing the characteristics of successive migrant cohorts leaving on their first trip to the United States between 1940 and 1978. Examination of trends should provide insights into how and why U.S. bound migration has grown so dramatically in recent years, both in the community under study and throughout rural Mexico.

This analysis represents an extension of previous work by Reichert and Massey (1979), who examined patterns of migration from a rural sending community characterized by high rates of seasonal migration to the United States. By 1978, three-quarters of town families—or 80 percent of the total population—were dependent on income earned by one or more family members working in the U.S., principally in agricultural jobs. The migrant force included large numbers of women and children. A majority of town migrants possessed valid immigration papers which entitled them to settle permanently in the United States. However, all of these individuals maintained permanent residences in the home commu-

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nity, using their U.S. resident visas only as *de facto* work permits enabling unrestricted access to the United States. Thus, migration from the subject community is a seasonal phenomenon since the vast majority of migrants—legal as well as illegal—return to Mexico each year following periods of temporary employment in the United States. This article examines the historical trends that gave rise to such a pattern of seasonal migration, a pattern characterized by the widespread participation of men, women and children many of whom are legal U.S. residents.

DATA

The data for this paper were gathered over the course of a twelve month field investigation conducted in the Mexican town of Guadalupe[1], a rural community of 2,621 people located in the northern portion of the state of Michoacán. The study covered all individuals who maintained residences in Guadalupe, whether or not they were present at the time fieldwork was conducted. Thus, migrants who had been living in the United States for several years were included unless they no longer maintained households in town.

Data on migration were obtained by an indirect approach which entailed gathering together a diversified group of informants to provide detailed information on other residents with whom they were familiar. Data sheets were prepared for each household in the community. Detailed records were compiled on the prior migration history of each household member, including information on current immigration status, date of first trip, date of immigration and previous migrant experience.

A total of twenty-six informants, representing a cross-section of the overall community in terms of age, sex and occupation assisted in compiling the material. These people were carefully instructed to avoid giving information about which they were not certain. All data gathered in this way were methodically cross-checked against that from other informants, with information on each migrant generally being compared across a minimum of six informants. When discrepancies were discovered in the data, further inquiries were made until the investigator felt certain that accurate information had been obtained. In cases where it was not possible to resolve conflicting reports, entries were classified as unknown.

RESULTS

Overall Trends in U.S. Bound Migration

Town residents with U.S. migrant experience were divided into eight

[1]Guadalupe is a fictitious name chosen to protect the anonymity of the town and its people.

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cohorts based upon the year of their first trip to the United States[2]. Selected characteristics of each of these migrant cohorts are presented in Table 1.

There is a dramatic increase in the number of migrants leaving Guadalupe from 1940 to 1978. Although numbers in the earlier cohorts are biased downward due to the fact that some older migrants died prior to the research period in 1978, and later cohorts are larger partly because of Guadalupe's population growth in general, neither mortality nor population growth can account for the great size differential between the earlier and later cohorts. Between 1940 and 1978, cohort size increased more than thirty times, roughly ten times the rate of population growth.

There have also been marked changes in the composition of cohorts over the last thirty-eight years. Cohorts have become progressively younger and more feminine. No female migrants left Guadalupe before 1965. By 1975–78, however, women made up the majority of those leaving on their first trip north. Similarly, before 1960, the migration of children was unheard of, but by 1975–78, 66 percent of all migrants were under fifteen years of age. Between 1940 and 1978, the average age of migrants dropped from thirty to approximately ten.

Table 1 reveals two distinct periods in the history of U.S. bound migration from Guadalupe: the *bracero* period, from 1940 to 1964;[3] and the post-*bracero* period from 1965 to 1978. During the former era, migrants were exclusively males of labor force age. Nearly all those

[2]Although the term "cohort" is used throughout this paper, it is not technically correct. Information was tabulated only on migrants alive at the time fieldwork was conducted in 1978. True migrant cohorts would also include indivduals who left on their first trip to the United States after 1940, but who died or moved away before 1978. Since 1940, sixty-three migrants have left Guadalupe permanently to live in the United States, and the number of migrants who have died is not known. In spite of these problems, there is good reason to believe the trends reported in the cohorts. First, townspeople are unanimous in reporting that no women or children went north before 1960, so the rapid rise shown after 1960 is no doubt real. Moreover, the reported decline in age across cohorts is probably even more pronounced than that reported here. As one moves back in time, it becomes increasingly likely that the oldest migrants in each cohort have died, thereby biasing average age downward. Since we observe a decline from high to low average age over time, this bias is conservative. Finally, it is unlikely that the remarkable increase in cohort size is solely an artifact of the way cohorts were constructed. While reported cohort size is clearly smaller than true size among earlier cohorts due to the effect of mortality, this bias cannot account for the observed thirty-fold increase over time. Nor does the exclusion of sixty-three permanent outmigrants seriously alter our interpretation. Of those who moved away, thirty-five were children and eleven were women, so that at least forty-six of the sixty-three began migrating after 1960, leaving seventeen who may have begun earlier. Thus the age-sex composition of permanent outmigrants suggests the same temporal distribution of first trips, casting doubt on the seriousness of possible biases arising form their exclusion.

[3]The *bracero* program was established in 1942 by a bilateral agreement between the governments of Mexico and the United States. Laborers were recruited by the Mexican

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TABLE 1

SELECTED CHARACTERISTICS OF MIGRANT COHORTS LEAVING GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN ON FIRST TRIP TO THE UNITED STATES, 1940–78.

	1940–44	1945–49	1950–54	1955–59	1960–64	1965–69	1970–74	1975–78
Number of Migrants	15	26	33	36	57	87	459	322
Percent Female	0	0	0	0	0	23.0	44.0	53.1
Percent Under Age 15 Years	0	0	0	0	3.5	25.0	46.2	66.5
Average Age	29.9	28.6	24.0	21.4	22.3	17.6	16.7	10.5
Percent Going as *Braceros*	93.3	92.3	84.8	97.2	21.0	0	0	0
Percent Going as Illegals	0	7.7	15.2	2.8	28.1	32.2	23.3	22.7
Percent Going as Legals	0	0	0	0	50.9	67.8	76.7	77.3

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leaving Guadalupe for the U.S. during this time did so as *braceros*. From 1940 to 1964, relatively few migrated to work illegally[4] in the United States. Those who traveled north as illegals during these years indicated they did so only because they were unable to obtain *bracero* contracts.

The period 1960-64 brought a sharp reduction in the number of Mexican contract laborers admitted to the United States under the *bracero* program, from over 400,000 annually in the mid-1950s, to about 170,000 before the program's termination in 1964. Due to these reductions, *bracero* contracts became increasingly difficult to obtain during the final years of the program. As a result, the percentage of migrants leaving Guadalupe as illegals jumped from 3 percent in 1955-59 to 28 percent in 1960-64.

After 1964, the composition of migrant cohorts underwent a marked transformation. Women and children began migrating and the number of Guadalupenos traveling north as legal U.S. residents rose dramatically as a result of the end of the *bracero* program, which had been limited to males of labor force age. By the end of the program in 1964 many *braceros* had become U.S. resident aliens. Moreover, most of the migrants leaving Guadalupe after 1964 were their wives and children. Under the family reunification provisions of the 1965 amendments to the Immigration and Nationality Act, wives and unmarried sons or daughters were able to obtain resident visas with relative ease. Unlike other Western Hemisphere immigrants, immediate relatives of resident aliens were exempt from labor certification requirements[5] which were intended to restrict immigration from Western Hemisphere nations.

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government and then sent to camps on the U.S. side of the border where employment, wages and transportation to job sites were arranged by the U.S. government, first by the Department of Agriculture and later by the Department of Labor. The maximum length of stay was six months. Originally formulated to ease manpower shortages during the Second World War, the program was extended by a series of acts until 1964 when, under pressure from organized labor and other interests, it was allowed to lapse. At its height in 1956, over 400,000 *braceros* were brought into the United States for work (*See*, Galarza, 1964; Cornelius, 1978; North and LeBel, 1978).

[4]This paper uses the term "illegal migrants" or simply "illegals" to refer to individuals entering the United States without valid immigration papers. The term encompasses those migrants who are simply undocumented in the sense that they do not hold any entry permit, those who have obtained fraudulent documents, as well as those who have been granted temporary entry permits, the terms of which have been violated by overstaying the designated time and by engaging in work.

[5]Labor certification requires U.S. employers to file applications with the U.S. Department of Labor, specifying the skills needed and the wages to be paid to the would-be immigrant. Employers must demonstrate that they have tried to locate a worker from the U.S. labor market. Labor certification is granted to individuals on a case by case basis after initial review by the State Employment Service, and then by the regional office of the Department of Labor's Employment and Training Administration. For further information, *see*, North (1971), or North and LeBel (1978).

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The proportion of migrant cohorts leaving as illegals has remained between 20 and 30 percent since 1960, falling somewhat over time due to the great increase in legal migration. However, illegal migration has now come to represent virtually the only way for those without family ties to a resident alien to enter the United States. As a result, the number of illegal migrants has steadily increased throughout the 1960s and 1970s.

In summary, overall trends reveal an early predominance of labor force males migrating to the U.S. for work as *braceros*, followed by a period in which increasing numbers of women and children began migrating with U.S. resident visas. While periods of legal, illegal and *bracero* migration tend to predominate at different times, they nonetheless overlap to a considerable degree, and it is instructive to break down each migrant cohort into its legal, illegal and *bracero* components for further analysis.

Trends Among Bracero Cohorts

Table 2 presents migrant cohorts leaving Guadalupe for work in the U.S. as *braceros* between 1940 and 1964. As was evident from the previous table, these cohorts are comprised exclusively of males of labor force age, primarily family heads seeking agricultural wage labor in the U.S. as a means to support their wives and children. There is a tendency for cohorts to become younger from the beginning to the end of the *bracero* program, indicating the increased participation of older sons as the *bracero* years progressed.

An important finding of Table 2 is the high percentage of *braceros* who ultimately went on to apply for and receive U.S. resident visas, or green cards. With the exception of the 1960–64 cohort, between 60 and 80 precent of each cohort eventually managed to adjust status to that of legal U.S. resident.

The timing of this adjustment is significant. The lag between the first trip and receipt of the green card is such that each *bracero* cohort, regardless of its date, tended to accomplish the adjustment of status during the 1960s, primarily during the period 1960–1964. By the late 1950s and early 1960s, it was becoming clear to Guadalupenos that the days of the *bracero* program were numbered, and that in the future they could no longer rely on being able to return to the United States as contract laborers. With the end of the program in sight, most *braceros* obtained letters from their U.S. employers sponsoring them as immigrants, and were granted permanent resident status under the liberal provisions of the 1952 Immigration and Nationality Act in force at that time[6]. With a green

[6]The 1952 Immigration and Nationality Act did not require prior labor certification for immigrants. A Department of Labor review was generally initiated only after a complaint

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TABLE 2

SELECTED CHARACTERISTICS OF *Bracero* COHORTS LEAVING GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN ON FIRST TRIP TO THE UNITED STATES, 1940–1978.

	1940–44	1945–49	1950–54	1955–59	1960–64	1965–69	1970–74	1975–78
Number of Migrants	14	24	28	35	12	0	0	0
Percent Female	0	0	0	0	0	—	—	—
Percent Under Age 15 Years	0	0	0	0	0	—	—	—
Average Age	30.9	29.4	23.1	21.4	23.6	—	—	—
Percent Who Eventually Obtained a Resident Visa	64.3	62.5	71.4	82.9	50.0	—	—	—
Percent Now Migrating as Illegals	0	0	10.7	11.4	25.0	—	—	—
Average Time Between First Trip & Receipt of Visa (years)	20.0	19.3	11.9	4.9	3.6	—	—	—

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card, these men could enter the United States at will. Unlike *bracero* contracts, there were no restrictions on the length of time they could stay or the type of work they could perform. In this sense, the green card was a permanent pass. Resident immigrants were free to seek jobs anywhere in the United States and could come and go as they pleased, thereby ensuring a constant source of support for themselves and their families.

Some *braceros,* however, were unable to adjust their status, particularly those who began migrating during the final years of the program. Leaving late, they did not have sufficient time to build "equity" in the United States. As a result, many of these individuals were forced to return north as illegals or abandon migrating altogether. For many who could not obtain legal documentation, illegal migration was the only means of ensuring continued support for their families at a level to which they had grown accustomed with the money brought in by U.S. wage labor.

Trends Among Illegal Cohorts

Table 3 presents information on cohorts of illegal migrants from Guadalupe. The large jump in the number of illegals leaving between 1960 and 1964 corresponds to the phasing out of the *bracero* program. With the end of the program and the passage in 1965 of restrictive amendments to the Immigration and Nationality Act, the size of illegal migrant cohorts increased dramatically. For those without kinship ties to green card holders, illegal migration now represented the only available means of working in the United States.

Since 1960, the flow of illegal migrants to the United States has been characterized by the increased participation of women and children. While the 1960-64 cohort contained no women, by 1975-78 women made up 47 percent of those leaving illegally for the U.S. Similarly, in the 1960-64 cohort, only 7 percent of migrants were children under fifteen. Among those leaving during 1975-78, however, approximately 23 percent were children.

These trends developed partially as a by-product of the increase in legal migration. When a majority of family members possess U.S. resident visas, the family often migrates north as a unit. Those without proper documentation, particularly if they are old enough to work, frequently accompany other family members to the United States illegally. Because of the order in which visa applications are typically made, migrating family members without documentation are most likely to be female and young. Hence, somewhat fewer than half the women and children who left as illegals after 1965 did so as members of family units containing

had been lodged. With no numerical restrictions or preference quotas, legal immigration was relatively easy for Western Hemisphere natives.

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TABLE 3

SELECTED CHARACTERISTICS OF ILLEGAL MIGRANT COHORTS LEAVING GUADALUPE, MICHOACÁN ON FIRST TRIP TO THE UNITED STATES, 1940–1978.

	1940–44	1945–49	1950–54	1955–59	1960–64	1965–69	1970–74	1975–78
Number of Migrants	0	2	5	1	16	28	107	73
Percent Female	—	0	0	0	0	7.1	10.3	46.6
Percent Under Age 15 Years	—	0	0	0	6.3	17.9	8.4	23.3
Average Age	—	19.5	28.6	20.0	23.5	19.8	21.7	18.9
Percent Who Eventually Obtained a Resident Visa	—	0	40.0	100	37.5	14.3	11.2	2.7
Percent Still Migrating as Illegals	—	0	0	0	37.5	67.9	77.6	89.0
Average Time Between First Trip & Receipt of Visa (years)	—	—	14.0	7.0	6.3	2.7	4.1	2.0

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other legal members. Under current immigration law, such people, because they belong to families which contain green card holders, will probably be able to adjust status in the future and migrate as legals.

In general, women and children, unless they travel to the United States as members of a family unit containing green card holders, become illegal migrants only under situations of extreme economic hardship, such as a widowed or abandoned woman left with children and no means of support. In some cases, if the children of a widowed woman are boys and over age twelve, they will strike out for the north on their own, hoping to earn money to support their mother and siblings still in Mexico. There have been several instances in Guadalupe of thirteen or fourteen year old boys migrating north under such circumstances. On the other hand, single mothers have, in a few cases, left small infants in the care of relatives and migrated to the U.S. in search of work.

During the *bracero* period, townspeople migrating as illegals had moderate success in acquiring U.S. resident visas, with about 40 percent of those leaving during that time ultimately managing to adjust status. Like *braceros,* the lag between first trip and adjustment of status indicates that these individuals tended to receive their green cards in the early to mid-1960s.

Since 1965, however, relatively few of those leaving Guadalupe as illegal migrants have been able to adjust status, in spite of the fact that many have family ties to green card holders. Although many of these individuals, particularly those who began migrating during the 1970s, have had less time to accomplish adjustment than those leaving before 1965, changes in U.S. immigration law have made it more difficult for post-1965 illegal migrants to acquire U.S. resident visas.

Consequently, while townspeople who migrated illegally during the years of the *bracero* program were often able to obtain sponsorship letters from their employers, and in this way secure a green card, this avenue was curtailed by the 1965 amendments which required labor certification prior to immigration. Moreover, amendments passed in 1976 made it difficult even for those with family ties to adjust status. By placing Mexico under the 20,000 per country quota limitation, the number of visas available to relatives of U.S. resident aliens was halved, thereby increasing the delay and difficulty of obtaining a green card.

Trends Among Legal Cohorts

As can be seen from Table 4, the number of individuals leaving Guadalupe as legal U.S. migrants has grown phenomenally in recent years. Prior to 1960, no migrants left on their initial trip to the United States with

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TABLE 4

SELECTED CHARACTERISTICS OF LEGAL MIGRANT COHORTS LEAVING GUADALUPE, MICHOACAN ON FIRST TRIP TO THE UNITED STATES, 1940-78.

	1940-44	1945-49	1950-54	1955-59	1960-64	1965-69	1970-74	1975-78
Number of Migrants	0	0	0	0	29	59	352	249
Percent Female	—	—	—	—	0	30.5	54.3	55.0
Percent Under Age 15 Years	—	—	—	—	3.4	28.6	57.7	79.1
Average Age	—	—	—	—	21.7	16.6	15.2	8.1

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resident visas. By 1970–74, 352 individuals had left on their first trip north with green cards in hand. Although these people are entitled to permanent residence in the United States, the vast majority return to Guadalupe each year where they maintain permanent homes.

Between 1960 and 1978, there was a very clear tendency for legal migrant cohorts to become younger and more feminine. In the 1960–64 cohort, there were no females and few individuals below the age of fifteen, while in the 1975–78 cohort, 55 percent were female and 79 percent were children under fifteen.

These trends stem from the order in which visa applications are generally made by family heads who are legal U.S. migrants. Initial visa requests are usually submitted on behalf of male children who are old enough to work, usually 15 years or older, as they are considered to be more capable of earning large amounts of money in the United States than are women. After the eldest sons have received their green cards, applications are submitted for wives and older daughters. When all family members who are old enough to work have obtained their visas, efforts are then made to "immigrate" younger children, those still too small to perform wage labor.

The first immigrant visas were obtained by former *braceros* beginning in the late 1950s and extending through the late 1960s, by which time virtually all *braceros* who would obtain resident visas had done so. Beginning with the 1960–64 cohort, townspeople began migrating to the United States for the first time as legals with no previous migrant experience. This cohort was comprised of males, almost all old enough to work, representing the eldest sons of former *braceros* who had become legal migrants. With the 1965–69 cohort, the process of "immigrating" older males continued. During this time, however, the first women and small children also began receiving their resident visas and going north. During 1970–74, the process of securing green cards for women and children continued, until by 1975–78 the vast majority of U.S. resident visas were acquired by children, most of whom were female.

These trends suggest the gradual emergence of a pattern of family migration among legal migrants. By 1978, a number of families had succeeded in legalizing all their members. Hence, they could travel north as a group, avoiding the periods of family separation that had been necessary in the past. By 1978, seven families were traveling north with more than ten members, and fifty were migrating with five members or more. This pattern of family migration is of very recent origin. While it is too early to tell whether it will continue to develop, barring changes in U.S. immigration policy, the historical trends certainly seem to point in this direction.

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SUMMARY AND DISCUSSION

Examination of migrant cohorts leaving the rural Mexican town of Guadalupe between 1940 and 1978 indicates several broad trends. Migrants are becoming younger and are more likely to be women, a fact particularly true of legal migrants, but also of illegals. If present trends continue, women and children in the future can be expected to play an increasingly important role in the seasonal migration of Guadalupenos to the United States.

There has also been a steady increase in the predominance of legals in the migrant stream. By 1975–78, 77 percent of all migrants leaving Guadalupe on their first trip north possessed valid U.S. resident visas. Yet, it should be pointed out that while the relative proportion of migrants leaving as illegals has declined in recent years, the absolute number has increased. Given the high rate of population increase in Guadalupe (currently running at an annual rate of 3.2%) and the lack of local employment opportunities, combined with recent amendments to U.S. immigration law which make it virtually impossible for Mexicans to immigrate without family ties to citizens or resident aliens, the continued growth of illegal migration seems likely.

Analysis of migrant cohorts also shows how the current situation of extensive seasonal migration to the U.S. developed. During the *bracero* program, men from Guadalupe began going north for seasonal wage labor at the invitation and encouragement of the U.S. government. During the period 1940 to 1964, 113 men—mostly family heads—migrated north to work as *braceros*. However, when the *bracero* program was terminated unilaterally by the United States in 1964, these men did not stop going north. Virtually all continued to work seasonally in the United States, either illegally or as legal U.S. residents. Indeed, the majority of them managed to adjust status by the end of the 1960s.

In the years following the *bracero* program, the number of Guadalupenos migrating to the United States increased significantly as former *braceros* began acquiring U.S. resident visas for their wives and children through the family reunification provisions of U.S. immigration law. Beginning with the oldest male children, wives, elder daughters and finally small children were "immigrated", until entire families became legal U.S. migrants, dramatically changing the composition of the seasonal migrant flow. At the same time, illegal migration continued to increase among those not related to green card holders, due to the absence of any other means of entering the United States.

In short, the current situation of extensive U.S. migration among Guadalupenos had its genesis in the U.S. conceived and sponsored *bracero* program. Among male migrants now age thirty or more, 52

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percent began migrating as *braceros*. Rather than giving up a source of livelihood upon which they had come to depend, Guadalupenos quite logically elected to keep returning north by whatever means available following the program's termination in 1964. In this sense, the current "problem" of Mexican migration is at least partially one of U.S. creation, a point that has also been made by other scholars (*See*, Cardenas, 1976; Cornelius, 1978).

Finally, the dramatic increase in the number of women and children who began migrating during the 1970s may signal the emergence of a wholly new pattern of family migration, one in which entire families go north, rather than only single male family heads as was previously the case. By 1978, approximately one-quarter of all families containing legal migrants were traveling north with five or more members. While the majority of these families still return to Guadalupe each year, they are now beginning to stay in the United States for longer periods of time. As of 1978, fourteen town families had been away for two years or more. Whether these developments signal the beginning of a trend towards permanent as opposed to seasonal or "shuttle" migration is unclear.

If the trends found in Guadalupe are at all representative of conditions in other towns and villages throughout rural Mexico characterized by high rates of U.S. migration, then several inferences can be made. First, the seasonal migrant flow between Mexico and the United States is no longer restricted to working age males. Evidence from Guadalupe suggests that women and children now represent important components of the flow of both legal and illegal migrants. We concur with North and Houstoun's (1976) view that women and children are often underrepresented in studies of Mexican migration, particularly in those based on samples of illegal migrants apprehended by the INS. This view is consistent with studies of unapprehended individuals which tend to show more women and children among migrants (*See*, Keely *et al.*, 1978; Cornelius, 1976; Ugalde *et al.*, 1979).

Research findings from Guadalupe also suggest that seasonal migrants are increasingly likely to be legal U.S. resident aliens traveling from their homes in Mexico to work in the United States. This would imply that the net annual flow of permanent Mexican immigrants into the United States may be significantly less than gross figures indicate. This view is also consistent with Warren's (1979) estimates of net emigration from the U.S. which showed Mexico leading all other nationalities, with the rate increasing between the late 1960s and early 1970s.

However, the long tradition of seasonal migration may soon change with the emergence of patterns of family migration. While it is possible that entire families of legal migrants may continue to shuttle back and forth between the United States and Mexico, the presence of additional

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family members acts as an impediment to seasonal migration. Sheer numbers make recurrent movement more difficult and complicated. In Guadalupe, some families are beginning to extend their stay in the U.S. beyond the traditional yearly cycle to two, three and even four years. If this is indicative of a trend towards full-time U.S. residence among individuals who are now seasonal migrants, we may find an increase in the number of permanent Mexican immigrants in years to come.

At the same time, there are various social and economic factors which serve to encourage the tradition of seasonal migration among Mexican workers. By U.S. standards, unskilled agricultural labor carries low prestige. Depressed wages and fluctuating market conditions make socioeconomic advancement of Mexican migrants very difficult in this country. On the other hand, in rural Mexico, U.S. labor carries considerable prestige and wages earned by migrants are astronomical by local standards. Seasonal work in the U.S. represents a dependable source of income which, over an extended period, brings considerable revenue into rural communities, enabling marked socioeconomic advancement among legal migrants. Indeed, in Guadalupe, green card holders have in many ways become a new elite, living at a considerably higher level then most illegals and nonmigrants.

Ultimately, however, the future of seasonal migration depends in large part on developments in the United States which lie beyond the control of migrants themselves. For example, a more restrictive U.S. border policy could severely curtail the seasonal movement of illegal migrants, forcing them either to cease traveling north or remain in the United States in an effort to avoid the risks involved in recurrent border crossings. Ironically, a tightened border policy could actually serve to increase the stock of illegal aliens if many elect to remain in the United States (or elect to remain longer) rather than returning home to Mexico.

The seasonal flow of legal migrants could also be severely curtailed by more stringent residency requirements. While a 1974 ruling by the Supreme Court held that permanent resident aliens residing abroad and commuting to work in the United States are entitled to maintain their status as U.S. residents (Fragomen, 1975), Congress could enact changes in the act to preclude this kind of seasonal migration.

Perhaps the most serious threat to seasonal migration, however, lies in the mechanization of U.S. agriculture which, up until now, has been a major source of seasonal employment for Mexican workers. Rising production costs brought about by higher wage demands stemming from the unionization of field laborers, particularly by the United Farm Workers, have encouraged many growers to substitute machines for hand labor. Already, the majority of California tomatoes are machine harvested and significant inroads are also being made in the mechanized harvesting

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of lettuce, cling peaches, wine grapes and other fruits and vegetables. In the past ten years alone, between 60,000 and 100,000 farmworkers have been displaced by machines in California. By 1987, it is predicted that 128,000 more agricultural jobs will be eliminated—roughly 68 percent of the state's present peak season agricultural labor force (Lindsay, 1979).

If these trends continue in other parts of the country, many seasonal migrants now performing agricultural labor in the United States will be unable to find such jobs in the next ten to twenty years. As a result, these individuals will begin seeking commercial, industrial, construction and service jobs in the U.S. urban areas. Indeed, the shift from agricultural to urban based occupations by Mexican migrants has been an emerging pattern since the mid-1960s (North and Houstoun, 1976; Villalpando *et al.*, 1977; Leahy and Castillo, 1977; Cornelius, 1978). However, urban based jobs tend to be full-time rather than seasonal. Furthermore, those jobs available to unskilled Mexican workers in U.S. cities are oftentimes less remunerative than agricultural field work. As such, they do not permit migrants to return home as frequently, or for such extended periods, as is now possible.

Thus, the continued mechanization of U.S. agriculture, together with the implementation of more restrictive immigration policies and the rise in family migration, could all conspire to end a tradition of seasonal migration that has developed in rural Mexico over the past several generations. While the outcome of such future developments remains speculative, the next two decades should prove to be pivotal in the history of Mexican migration.

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